

DELPH-IN Summit 2026

Perspectives for Large Scale Speaking Assessment within the MOOC: English Pronunciation in a Global World

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English Pronunciation in a Global World

In this course, you will improve your English pronunciation skills and learn about speaking English in today's globalised world.

★★★★★ 4.8 (432 reviews) 121.758 enrolled on this course

Syllabus

- Week 1: What is important in English pronunciation?
[Show weekly breakdown](#)
- Week 2: English vowels
[Show weekly breakdown](#)
- Week 3: English consonants
[Show weekly breakdown](#)
- Week 4: Suprasegmental features in English
[Show weekly breakdown](#)

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4 weeks

4 hours per week

Digital certificate when eligible

Intermediate level

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MOOC: English Pronunciation in a Global World

- MOOC course English Pronunciation in a Global World, by **Laura Rupp** (VU Amsterdam)
- **Embrace diversity while focusing on mutual understanding/intelligibility**
- Many participants: course relies mostly on **self-assessment/ peer-feedback**
- Generates A LOT of data...
- **Goal: use language technology to automate feedback**
- Received a small grant for 2 RAs for 1 year
- Offered thesis topics as “research internships”



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Pronunciation/Speech Learner Corpus

- MOOC data (word list + reading passage)
- Data collection is **ongoing**
- **Wordlist:** (hand/checked) segmented into single word recordings
- Two small wordlist (subsets) datasets
 - 2024 (~2,100 recordings, ~40 students, ~33% unintelligible, **binary + feature annotation**)
 - 2025 (~10,200 recordings, ~ 200 students, 43% unintelligible, **binary annotation**)
- **Reading Passage:** just started
- Annotation of ‘intelligibility’ is ongoing, not a simple matter

1. pit	13. bout	25. father	37. fair	49. paws
2. pet	14. beer	26. farther	38. nose	50. meet
3. pat	15. bear	27. pull	39. knows	51. meat
4. put	16. bird	28. pool	40. plate	52. mate
5. putt	17. bard	29. pole	41. weight	
6. pot	18. board	30. paul	42. poor	
7. bee	19. city	31. doll	43. pour	
8. bay	20. seedy	32. cot	44. pore	
9. buy	21. hat	33. caught	45. paw	
10. boy	22. dance	34. fir	46. tide	
11. boot	23. daft	35. fern	47. tied	
12. boat	24. half	36. fur	48. pause	

Adapted from: Arthur Hughes, Peter Trudgill & Dominic Watts. 2012.
English accents and dialects: an introduction to social and regional
varieties of English in the British Isles. London: Routledge.

Developing an Annotation Schema

- Creation of a **set of guidelines** for annotations
 - Based on e.g. Jenkins (2002), functional load, MOOC peer review, input from students
- Establishment of (un)intelligibly boundaries variants for each word in the word list - **following *Learner English* (Swan & Smith, 2001)**.
- As we **annotate, adjudicate and revise**, the Guidelines are updated and refined.
- Inter-annotator agreement is fairly high, **Vowel Quality is the worse class** (i.e. “unaccepted Substitution” vs. “other substitution”)

rhoticity	MISSING		
vowel length	SHORTENING	LENGTHENING	
vowel quality	UNACCEPTED SUBSTITUTION	OTHER SUBSTITUTION	
consonant initial	MISSING ASPIRATION	SUBSTITUTION	
consonant middle	SUBSTITUTION		
consonant final	SUBSTITUTION		
extra sound	INITIAL	MIDDLE	END
missing sound	INITIAL	MIDDLE	END

Exploring Intelligibility as a Classification Task

- Four completed theses:
 - Whisper ASR as a baseline in Intelligibility Classification (2024) ★★ ★
 - Exploring Multimodal Large Language Models (2025) ★★ ★
 - Exploring the Impact of Continuous Pre-Training (2026) ★★ ★★
 - Exploring Phonetic Transcription Models (2026) ★★ ★★ ★
- A few new direction for new theses:
 - Exploring Ambiguity in Top-N predictions in ASR Models (2026/27)
 - Fine-tuning ASR w/ synthetic data produced by TTS models (2026/27)

Concluding Thoughts

- **New Collaborations**
 - Nicolas Ballier (Université Paris Cité, ALTAE lab)
 - Sylvain Coulange (Université Grenoble Alpes, LIDILEM Lab)
- **Two papers** in the pipeline this summer
 - Dataset + Word-level intelligibility classification
 - ASR encoder probability for Intelligibility of reading passages (collab w/ Ballier)
- **New “spontaneous speech” task** (collab w/Coulange)
 - Great links with **Grammatical Error Detection in Speech**
- Work towards corrective feedback for pronunciation
- Better integration with the MOOC



Thank you!

